

Prudence

‘You’ll come?’

I look down at my toes, conflicted on the inside. Ranjan stands in front of me, patiently waiting for an answer. It is these moments that I hate the worst, when I have to come up with an appropriate response for my best friend to cover my folly; when I have to give him a drawn-out explanation and justification for my actions. And as it happens, such moments come often.

What should I say? We have been planning this outing for two months now. I can just imagine Ranjan waiting breathlessly for the big day that was to be today. And yet, one look at my troubled face must have informed him that something is not right.

I must explain my case to him patiently and calmly. Then he might see sense more quickly. He might understand and forgive me. As it is, he respects my private life and understands that I have other appointments too. And... I’ll probably not tell him that I was informed about my tuition class that is barring me from going with him today, even before we decided upon the dates for our outing.

He’ll understand. He has tuitions himself. He knows the importance of attending those classes. He’ll understand that study is more important. And anyways, what good will it be to spend an entire day in the theatre, watching outrageous scenes of violence generating a bad influence on our minds, and in the food court, gobbling down junk after junk? Isn’t it wiser to spend it in a more productive engagement? Productive, such as studying. He can come over to my house after my tuitions. We’ll study together.

If I miss my tuition today, I’ll surely regret it when there is a surprise test or an exam. Moreover, isn’t it inadvisable to go out during these times? Should we not stay at home during the pandemic? That’s it! That’s it! Even he’ll understand now, that it is just *not* a good idea to go out today, even for him.

I resolutely look up to face him, and open my mouth to speak out my heart.

‘I’ll come.’

- Manan Garg
X-B